Climate Ambition Meets Urban Aspiration:

Green Tech, Urban Growth, and Sustainability Fix in New York City

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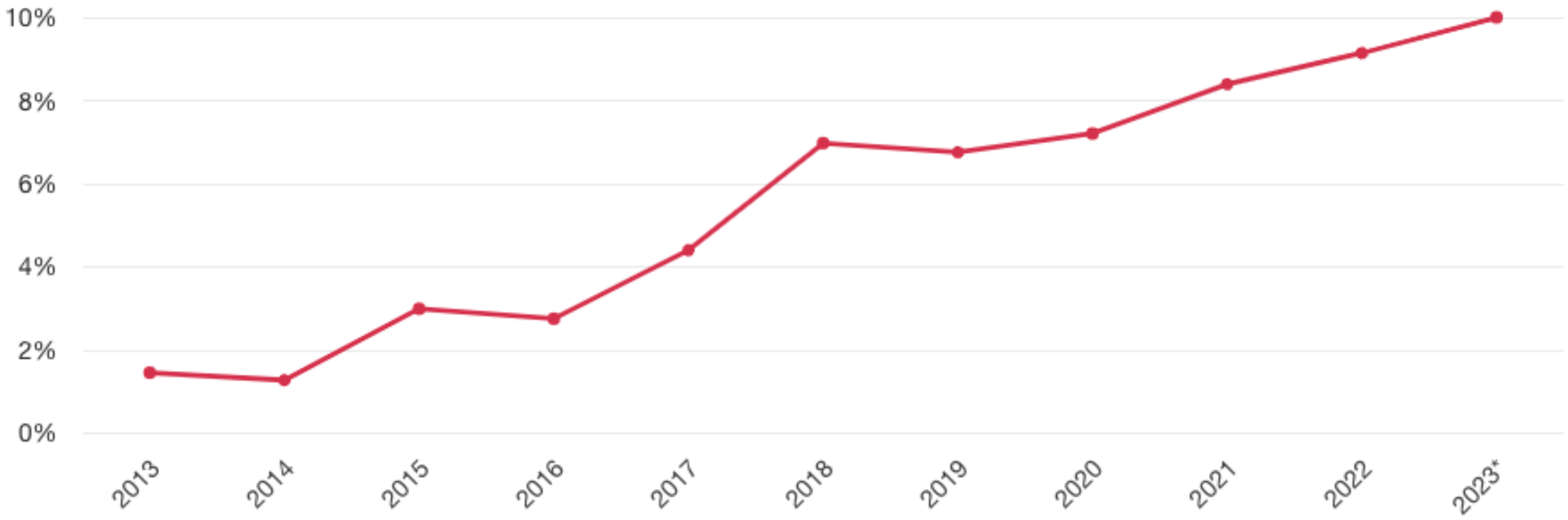
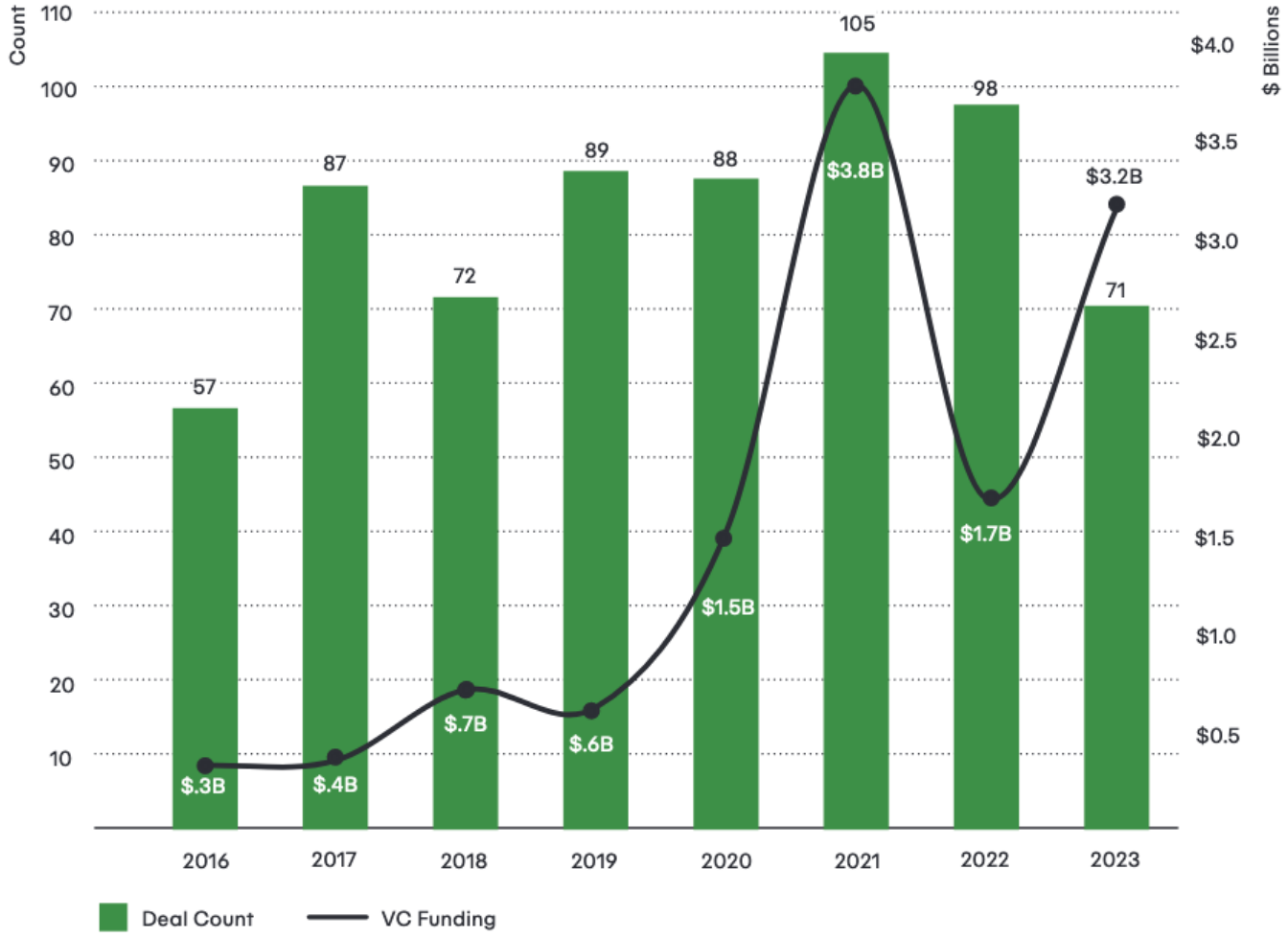
AAG 2026: The Institutional Life of Climate Governance

Relative to all start-up investments, green tech investment has increased



Climate tech investment as a percentage of venture capital and private equity investment
*Data for 2023 is current through the third quarter of the year.

VC investment in NYC-based green tech increased by 800%



RQ: What are the policy goals of green technologies, and do these projects prioritize addressing or mitigating the adverse effects of climate change?

GREEN

TECH

- Green is intertwined with sociometrical conditions in which it is used (Angelo, 2020; Beck, 2010)
- Green modernity as a narrative that frames climate action as an exclusively decarbonization endeavor (Riquito, 2023), thus perpetuating capitalist apparatus

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TECH

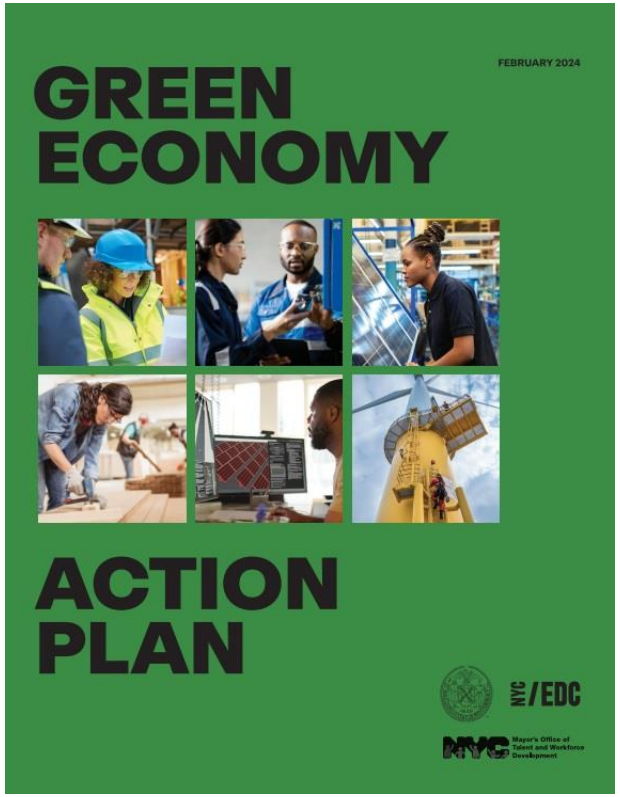
- Technology as a non-neutral entity, embedded in the world
- Technology beyond the high-tech narrative of capital (Bijker et al., 2012; de Laet & Mol, 2000; Law, 1987)

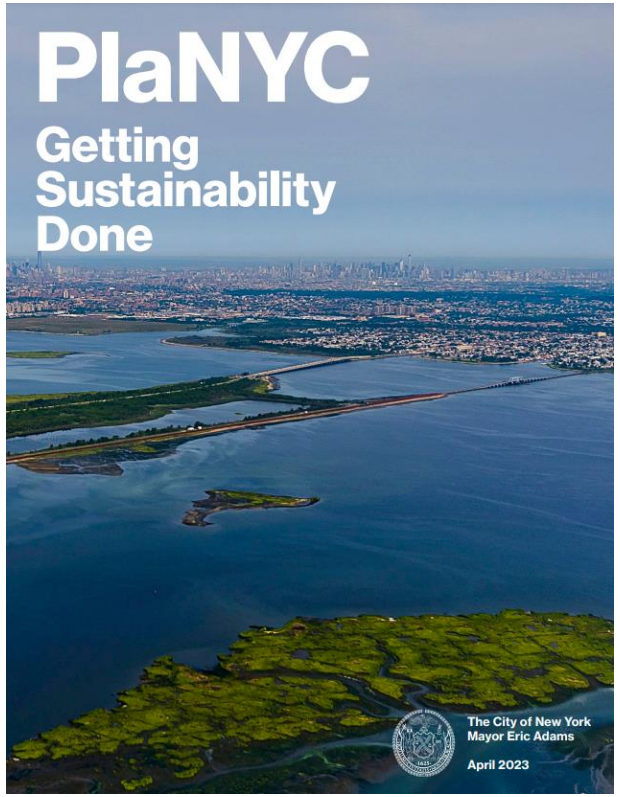
Recent policy focus on green technologies fosters urban growth and prioritizes economic development of cities to extract profit from land over all other concerns

(Digital) growth machine (Molotch, 2011; Rosen & Alvarez León, 2022)

Climate urbanism and capitalist dynamics of climate action (Shi, 2022)

Method: discourse analysis of policy documents, guided by a Foucauldian approach to discourse and an abductive research program (Dorschel 2024, Timmermans & Tavory, 2012)





5 ways green tech produce urban growth

1. LAND DEVELOPMENT FOR INNOVATION HUBS

2. GREEN BUILDING TECHNOLOGY FOR INNOVATION HUBS

3. GREEN BUILDING TECHNOLOGY AT OTHER SITES

4. LAND DEVELOPMENT FOR GREEN TECH AND INFRASTRUCTURE

5. PROFIT FROM DATA & ALGORITHMS

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IMPLICIT ASSUMPTIONS

(1) Green Tech is capable of dealing with climate change

(2) Green Tech should be "commercially successful"

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INVISIBLE PIPELINE OF GREEN TECH

SUSTAINABILITY FIX

harmonizing environmental protection + *economic growth* (Emiliano Scanu et al., 2020)

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